

BEFORE

In the 19th and early 20th centuries, Russia's rocky path led it from despotic Czarist rule through revolution, civil war, and the creation of a new state. In 1920 the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics was formed.

SIBERIAN WORK CAMPS

During the 19th century, political activists and criminals were sent to work in forced labor camps in Siberia (northeast Russia). Stalin vastly extended the use of these work camps.



PRISONERS IN SIBERIA, 1897

SOVIET DEMOCRACY

Lenin held Marxist <<334–35 beliefs and strove to achieve a “dictatorship of the proletariat.” After seizing power for the workers, the Communist Party's role was to guide them. In theory, workers held political power through locally elected councils, or “soviets,” but there was heavy state control and power was centralized in the Party.

When Lenin came to power after the Russian Revolution (see pp.378–79), he quickly established a highly centralized system of government. He banned all rival political parties, and empowered the Communist Party's dominant Central Committee to expel anyone who failed to follow the party line. Disagreements with Trotsky (see right) and other members soon led Lenin to favor Joseph Stalin, a rising star in the party. Stalin was already a member of the Politburo, the most powerful body of the regime, which made decisions on foreign relations, war, economics, and domestic policy, and the Orgburo, which was responsible for the Party's internal affairs. In 1922 he was appointed General Secretary of the Central Committee. After Lenin's death in January 1924, Stalin plotted to discredit and expel Central Committee

“Death solves all problems—no man, no problem.” JOSEPH STALIN

members who opposed his leadership, most notably Leon Trotsky (see opposite). All his rivals would eventually meet with violent deaths.

Stalinism

Over the course of Stalin's rule, Lenin's version of communism mutated into what became known as Stalinism. Between 1928–37, Stalin instituted the first and second Five Year Plans, huge and ambitious schemes that aimed to transform the Soviet Union into an industrialized society. While the rest of the developed world was suffering economic depression, Stalin achieved extraordinary growth (see pp.384–85).

Agriculture in the Soviet Union was also transformed. Frustrated by his dependence on a rebellious peasantry to provide grain for the exports needed to finance his industrial plans, Stalin enforced a policy of “collectivization.” Land belonging to peasants and kulaks (prosperous rural farmers) was confiscated and turned into vast farms that were collectively run and worked by cooperatives. It was initially

30 MILLION The number of Russians who moved into cities and industrialized regions between 1928 and 1937, the time of Stalin's Five Year Plans.

The Hammer and Sickle

In 1921, with revolution achieved, and civil war at an end, the Soviet Union entered a 20-year period of relative peace. Lenin and the Bolshevik Party could turn their attention to the task of transforming the former Russian Empire, putting Karl Marx's vision of communism into practice.

